

COLORED TROOPS IN THE FRENCH ARMY

A REPORT



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TROOPS IN THE FRENCH ARMY ***

COLORED TROOPS IN THE FRENCH ARMY

A REPORT

FROM THE DEPARTMENT OF STATE RELATING TO
THE COLORED TROOPS IN THE FRENCH ARMY AND
THE NUMBER OF FRENCH COLONIAL TROOPS
IN THE OCCUPIED TERRITORY



PRESENTED BY MR. LODGE

FEBRUARY 15 (calendar day, February 14), 1921.—Ordered to be printed

WASHINGTON
GOVERNMENT PRINTING OFFICE
1921

66TH CONGRESS }
3d Session

SENATE

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LETTER OF TRANSMITTAL.

DEPARTMENT OF STATE,
Washington, February 14, 1921.

Hon. HENRY CABOT LODGE,
United States Senate.

SIR: In response to an informal request made by your secretary of Mr. Bliss, of this department, on February 12, 1921, I have the honor to inclose for your consideration and that of your committee a copy of a letter, with its inclosures which I wrote to Mr. Porter, chairman of the Foreign Affairs Committee of the House, on the subject of French black troops on the Rhine; also a copy of a later letter to Mr. Porter, with its inclosure, a copy of a telegram from Mr. Wallace, giving the latest figures as to the number of French colonial troops now in the occupied territory.

I have the honor to be, sir,

Your obedient servant,

NORMAN H. DAVIS,
Acting Secretary.

COLORED TROOPS IN THE FRENCH ARMY.

JANUARY 17, 1921.

Hon. STEPHEN G. PORTER,
House of Representatives.

SIR: I have the honor to acknowledge the receipt of your letter of January 10, 1921, with which you inclose a copy of House joint resolution No. 433, introduced by Mr. Britten, and request that I furnish the Committee on Foreign Affairs with such facts concerning the conduct of French colored troops in the occupied territories of Germany as may be in the possession of the Department of State.

Protests concerning the conduct of French black troops in the Rhenish area began to reach the department toward the end of May, 1920. On June 12, 1920, a telegram was sent to the American embassy in Paris requesting information as to the truth of these allegations and asking what representations might be made to the French Government, if the reports appeared to have a basis of fact. (Appendix I). On June 25, 1920, Mr. Wallace telegraphed that an investigation had been promptly started and that he would arrange with Gen. Allen, in command of the American troops at Coblenz, to secure all possible facts. In a further telegram of this same date Mr. Wallace gave a short summary of the number of colonial troops employed by the French in the occupied territories, reported what Mr. Dresel, American commissioner in Berlin, had told him of the agitation in Germany, and suggested that he speak informally of the matter to M. Millerand. (Appendix II.) The Department of State authorized Mr. Wallace to speak to M. Millerand on the subject, and he reported on July 22 that this had been done. (Appendix II.)

In the meantime, on June 22, the department telegraphed Gen. Allen for such information as he might be able to furnish. This telegram was answered shortly on June 26, giving the number and origin of French colonial troops in the occupied region and an official report of the number of complaints made to the French during the period of occupation and the disposition made of these complaints. (Appendix IV.) On July 2 Gen. Allen

submitted a full and detailed report on the matter (Appendix V), in which he pointed out that the allegations of wholesale atrocities were false and intended for political propaganda, that there had been cases of serious misbehavior which had been punished by the French military authorities, that the number of convictions indicated an earnest effort on the part of the French authorities to deal justly with the accusations, and that the discipline of the Senegalese troops had not always been good. I especially commend this report to your attention as a clear and impartial statement of the case. That the French are attempting to maintain good relations with the people of the territory occupied by their armies is made evident in a telegram from Gen. Allen of August 19, in which he cites a French order instructing that "all members of the Army must be dignified, courteous, and just, thus setting the example to the German population of tolerance in order that good will and mutual respect may be established and promoted and ill will and hatred overcome." (Appendix VI.)

The department also consulted in this matter the American commissioner in Berlin, stating on June 15, 1920, that it was receiving many protests against the alleged misconduct of French black troops and that the phrasing of the protests suggested possible inspiration from a propaganda bureau. (Appendix VII.) Mr. Dresel replied that protests in Germany were general, emanating from all classes and political parties, that an extensive press propaganda had been carried on and that a mass meeting of protest was soon to be held in Berlin at which certain Americans were to speak. Mr. Dresel inclosed a memorandum on this subject. You will note in this memorandum which includes translations from the German press and a summary of the discussion in the Reichstag, various examples of gross exaggeration of facts, as, for example, the statement of the German foreign minister that France had transplanted "50,000 black and colored troops to the heart of white Europe," whereas Gen. Allen stated that the number of such troops, including regiments of Arabs, was in the vicinity of 20,000. May I call your particular attention in this memorandum also to the translation of the French answer to the German protests? I understand that there has been no official interchange of notes between the French and German Governments.

Mr. Dresel forwarded to the department also the original German edition of the pamphlet, "Colored Frenchmen on the Rhine," the American edition of

which, published by the New Times of Chicago, appears to be a literal translation with the addition of the words, "An appeal of white women to American womanhood." It is perhaps worth noting that this pamphlet was published not in the Rhineland, but in Berlin, and that the avoidance of names makes it impossible to verify or disprove the specific allegations. Furthermore as Mr. Dresel has pointed out to the department, practically all the alleged instances of misconduct by the French black troops cited in the German press give no reference to date or place and are therefore of little value as evidence.

On July 15 the American commissioner in Berlin sent to the department a translation of an account of the so-called American protest meeting against the use by France of colored troops in the Rhineland area, which was held in Berlin on the evening of July 4. In his covering dispatch Mr. Dresel pointed out that the addresses were bitterly anti-American as well as anti-French and that Miss Ray Beveridge and Mr. Scheffauer, both American citizens, were particularly vehement in their attacks on the American Government. I have thought it worth while to inclose this dispatch, with the accompanying translation, to call your attention to the competence of the witnesses on whose allegations this propaganda appears in large measure to be based.

Miss Ray Beveridge was formerly employed by the German embassy in Washington and was the organizer of "embargo conference" meetings in 1915. She states that she held a public meeting in the Reichstag Building to protest against the signing of the peace treaty. She refers to the former Emperor of Germany as "my Kaiser." Mr. Edwin Emerson, formerly a newspaper man in Berlin connected with the antially Continental Times, has been living in Germany since 1917. During and since the war he has been carrying on antiallied propaganda work in Germany. John W. DeKay was identified with the Huerta dictatorship and attempted to import into Mexico rifles and ammunition, which were intercepted by the United States at Vera Cruz. He was indicted on nine counts in New York in 1913 for obtaining money on false pretenses and is a fugitive from justice in the Atlantic National Bank case. He is said to be the treasurer of the bolshevist party in Switzerland. He carried a Mexican passport in December, 1920, and was at one time granted a German passport by the German legation in Berne. Mr. H. G. Scheffauer, born in San Francisco in 1878, has lived in Germany

since 1913. As coeditor of the Continental Times he contributed anti-American articles under assumed names. On January 6, 1919, he was indicted for treason—for writing, publishing, and distributing articles and propaganda in aid of the German cause. These people call themselves Americans, and as far as the department knows are the authors of most of the stories distributed in this country concerning the misconduct of the French black troops. It is necessary to speak of the Englishman, E. D. Morel, only because he is specifically mentioned in House joint resolution No. 433. Mr. Morel was, before the war, strongly anti-French and anti-Belgian. During the Moroccan crisis he upheld Germany and during the war was indicted under the defense of the realm act for sending uncensored letters to Switzerland. His articles on the “Black Terror” were published in the London Daily Herald, an extremely radical paper alleged to be subsidized by the Russian soviet government.

Finally, it should be called to the attention of your committee that these accusations against the French troops are also reaching America direct from Germany. As evidence of this there are inclosed photostat copies of two printed appeals sent in the mail from Germany to American citizens and by them forwarded to the department. The leaflet entitled “The Black Evil” reached America inclosed in a German magazine. You will note that there is no printer’s mark and that the American flag at the top is evidently intended to indicate that it was printed in America. Several of these leaflets have reached the department and copies have been sent to the Postmaster General for such action as he may see fit to take. The second leaflet, entitled “An Appeal to Americans,” contains the accusation against the French colored troops only as a further argument for American assistance.

As soon as the department received word of the introduction of House joint resolution No. 433 I telegraphed to Mr. Wallace for information as to the present personnel of the French troops of occupation. When his answer is received I shall be pleased to forward it to you. May I, however, call your attention to the fact that no recent allegations of misconduct of French soldiers have been made so far as the department is informed, all those detailed in the various published statements referring to a time prior to June 1, 1920.

In consideration of what I have said above, the facts that, although there were undoubtedly outrages, those proved guilty have been punished; that

official American testimony as well as that given by many reputable Germans largely disproves the specific but unverifiable charges made by witnesses whose impartiality is certainly questionable; that the accusations appear to be a method of anti-French propaganda; that the French have long since withdrawn the Senegalese troops which were the only pure Negro troops used; that there appear to be no accusations against the behavior of such French colonial troops as remain in the occupied territories; that Mr. Wallace has already discussed the matter with the French prime minister, it would appear to me inadvisable that the American Government should be asked to take any further action at the present time.

I am very glad to be able to furnish you with full information in this matter and request only that the inclosures herewith be considered as for your confidential use and that of the members of your committee.

I have the honor to be, sir,

Your obedient servant,

NORMAN H. DAVIS,
Acting Secretary.

APPENDIX I.

June 12, 1920.

AMERICAN EMBASSY, *Paris*:

Department is receiving telegrams and letters protesting against the use of African troops in occupied Germany by the French. Please give your views as to the truth of the accusations being made against the behavior of these troops and whether you believe these accusations are well founded. Advise department what you deem advisable in the way of representations to the French Government on this subject. It is not department's desire to lend too credulous an ear to these sensational reports and yet it may be of interest to the French Government to know that such reports are being persistently circulated and that they are having a harmful effect on public opinion, not being fully refuted.

COLBY.

APPENDIX II.

PARIS, *June 25, 1920.*

SECRETARY OF STATE,
Washington:

Gen. Allen reports that there are at present in occupied Germany regiments of Moroccans, Algerians, Zouaves, and Malgaches, but no Senegalese. According to my understanding the Algerian troops comprise natives of Algeria of French and French Arab stock, and some Mahomedans, not Negroes. The Moroccan regiments comprise Arabs and Mahomedans, not Negroes. The Malgaches are Malays from Madagascar, and the Zouaves are special infantry regiments, not Negroes.

Mixed blacks. Senegalese are Negroes.

The American commissioner states that agitation against the black troops is carried on by papers of all political opinions, that the German Government has formally protested to the French Government, that complaints have come from men of all classes, that the papers claim that America should understand the situation on account of our Negro question and charge that assaults have been made on German women, but that the facts can not be checked and that the American consul reported deep anger of population of Frankfort and vicinity over use of black troops. These troops have been withdrawn. French newspapers have denied German press reports on several occasions, but I have seen no official denial in the press or elsewhere.

Minister of War Lefevre, speaking in the chamber on June 17 regarding the army budget and the future of the French black troops, stated: "As for our black troops, we shall not tolerate the interested criticisms which are being made on the other side of the Rhine."

It is my belief that it would be a friendly act to inform Millerand that department is receiving many telegrams and letters of protest and that it may interest the French Government to know that the persistent reports are not fully refuted and are having a harmful effect upon public opinion.

WALLACE.



APPENDIX III.

PARIS, *July 22, 1920.*

SECRETARY OF STATE,
Washington, D. C.:

1431, July 22, 10 p. m.

Your 1185, June 29, 5 p. m. I have spoken in accordance with authorization to Millerand, who answered that he was quite aware of the campaign referred to and mentioned the recent activities in Berlin of an American woman. He expressed appreciation of the information that the reports had not been fully refuted and said he would take the necessary steps to that end.

WALLACE.

APPENDIX IV.

COBLENZ, *July 26, 1920.*

SECRETARY OF STATE,
Washington:

Your June 22, 5 p. m., regarding alleged mistreatment by French colored troops of German women. The average number of French Negro troops on the Rhine from January, 1919, to June, 1920, was 5,200. The number of North African troops, Arabs, and mixed blood, 20,000. All regiments of pure Negroes (Senegalese) were removed June 5, one regiment of Madagascar troops and a few individual Negro or Negroid remaining in other colonial troops. During entire period of occupation there were 66 cases of actual or alleged rape, sodomy, or similar offenses reported to French officials. The action taken resulted in 28 convictions, 11 acquittals, the other cases not being completed. The offenses included some insulting proposals and offensive conduct toward German women. The sentences varied from 30 days, to 10 years, confinement. Widespread reports and complaints in the German press are based on the foregoing cases and some others not officially reported to French officials, and while these reports have some foundation they are undoubtedly greatly exaggerated and are being used as propaganda against the French troops and are inspired by possibilities of war animosity. Investigation continuing. Full report follows.

APPENDIX V.

INTERALLIED RHINELAND HIGH COMMISSION,
AMERICAN DEPARTMENT,
Coblenz, Germany, July 2, 1920.

SIR: 1. In compliance with your cablegram of June 22, 1920, regarding alleged mistreatment of German women by French colored troops, and in elaboration of my cablegram of June 28, I submit the following report, based on a personal investigation conducted by Col. Le Vert Coleman, C. A. C., American liaison officer with the commanding general of the allied forces of occupation.

2. During the period from January, 1919, to June 1, 1920:

(a) The average number of Negro troops in the French Army of the Rhine was 5,200 men.

(b) The average number of French colonial troops composed of natives of Africa not of pure Negro blood, including distinct races such as Arabs from Algeria, Moroccans, etc., and mixed blood races, such as the Malgaches from Madagascar, who are Negroids, was 20,000 men. During the entire period from the first day of the occupation in 1918, to the 1st of June, 1920, 66 cases of alleged rape, attempted rape, sodomy, or attempted sodomy have been officially reported to the French military authorities, against their colored colonial troops in the occupied territories of the Rhinlands. Among these cases, there have been 28 convictions, including several cases where the intent was not fully proved, but punishment was given by minor courts corresponding to our summary and garrison courts, for indecent proposals and obscene handling of women and girls against their will. There have been 11 acquittals. There have been 23 investigations leading to trials, the results of which have not been published yet. There have been 6 cases where the offenders could not be found. The penalties inflicted have been varied; from 10 years at hard labor for aggravated cases of rape, to 30 days in prison for indecent mishandling of women.

3. At the present time, the Senegalese brigade having all left the Rhinelands between June 1 and 6, 1920, there actually remains but one regiment of troops of Negroid origin, the First Regiment of Chasseurs Malgaches. There are, however, a few individual Negroes or Negroids in the other French colonial regiments.

4. A very violent newspaper campaign attacking the French colonial troops, especially the Negro troops, broke out simultaneously throughout Germany coincident with the time of the French evacuation of Frankfurt and Darmstadt, and has continued up to the present time. It is unquestionably a fact that many gross exaggerations were circulated in the German press concerning the conduct of the French colonial troops. The allegations in the German press have been, for the most part, so indefinite as to time and place, and circumstance, as to leave it impracticable to verify the alleged facts, or to disprove them.

5. After all proper allowance is made for the natural difficulties, which always are to be expected in tracing crimes of this nature, due to the shame and distress of the victims, the great mass of the articles in the German press, by the simultaneous appearance all over Germany, and by the failure to cite time, place, and circumstance sufficiently clear to enable the truth to be ascertained, give to an impartial observer the impression of an adroit political move which would tend to sow antipathy to France in the other lands of the allied and associated powers, especially in America, where the Negro question is always capable of arousing feeling.

6. The Rheinische Zeitung and the Kolnische Volkszeitung, recently suspended for publishing attacks on the French colored colonial troops, admit under date of June 15, that they employed certain terms and expressions which they might better have omitted, due to the imperfection of the news coming for the most part from outside sources, says the Volkszeitung, and from Berlin says the Rheinische Zeitung. This tends to bear out the opinion noted above, which is further strengthened by dissentant voices in the South German press which protests against exaggerated accusations by other German papers against colored French troops.

7. These exaggerated attacks in the German press outside of the Rhinelands have, in several cases, been refuted by responsible officials (German) and

citizens of the Rhineland.

Herr Kohler, mayor of Worms; Herr Bischoff, police commissioner of Worms, referring to the Senegalese troops, reports to the Interallied Rhineland High Commission, that with the exception of one incident, the Senegalese troops in Worms have not committed any misdemeanor and have been under perfect discipline during their entire stay in Worms.

Herr Levy, from Kreuznach, and several Germans, have written open letters protesting against what they term unfair exaggerations in the German press against the troops.

8. Among gross exaggerations in the German press may be cited the following:

(a) Claim that there are 40,000 colored French troops in the Palatinate.

(b) Claim that Frankfort was occupied by 20,000 men entirely formed of Negro (Senegalese) troops. French official report shows that no Senegalese occupied Frankfort, but first Moroccan and Algerian tirailleurs and later French troops (white).

(c) Numerous atrocities in the Saar, where young women are said to have been forcibly abducted, raped, mutilated, killed, and their bodies thrown into manure piles. The burgermeister of Saarbrucken, the inspector of the Caserne Petain, Herr Welsch, proprietor of the manure pile; Wilhelm Roth, caretaker; Herr Geppert, employee, have all given written and oral testimony wholly refuting the accusations.

(d) Claim of the German press that large numbers of young Austrian girls who had come to the vicinity of Mainz to get away from the famine in Austria were raped. The Austrian Government is reported to have made an investigation through its consular service and to have found that not a single such case had occurred.

(e) Investigation by Col. Bonvialle, commanding the Twelfth Tirailleurs, May 21, 1920, concerning charges of sodomy near Euskirchen, with medical report, indicates that the charges could not be sustained.

(f) Claims in the Nauen Radio Service on April 29, 1920, that the working people of Alsace-Lorraine had protested, demanding the removal of the

Moroccan division from Alsace-Lorraine, when there was no part of those troops in Alsace-Lorraine.

9. On the other hand, undoubtedly many instances have occurred where women or girls have been assaulted and some where boys and men have been sodomized by members of the French colored colonial troops. See report above as to the official figures. There are undoubtedly cases which are not included in the official figures, due to the natural desire to keep out of obscene notoriety. For example, a case of attempted assault was reported June 14, 1920, from Saarbrücken which is not included in the French official figures. Some cases will never come to light, due to the natural feeling of shame of the women concerned, but they are, in my opinion, cases such as generally occur in any land when soldiery is for a long time quartered upon the population.

10. The impression gained from contact with and observation of the French colonial troops is that, as a general rule, they are quiet, orderly, and well behaved. Discipline has a purely relative value and is hardly of the same order as that which we would require. That the discipline of the Senegalese brigade was not always good, is established by the incidents which recently occurred at Marseille, when a part of these troops committed serious infractions of discipline when ordered aboard their transports.

11. The attitude of certain classes of German women toward the colored troops has been such as to incite trouble. On account of the very unsettled economic conditions, and for other causes growing out of the World War, prostitution is abnormally engaged in and many German prostitutes and women of loose character have openly made advances to the colored soldiers, as evidenced by numerous love letters and photographs which are now on file in the official records and which have been sent by German women to colored French soldiers. Several cases have occurred of marriages of German women with French Negro soldiers. One German girl of a first-class burgher family, her father a very high city functionary of a prominent city in the Rhinlands, recently procured a passport to rejoin her fiance in Marseille. He was a Negro sergeant. Other Negro soldiers have had French wives here, and the color line is not regarded either by the French or the Germans as we regard it in America; to keep the white race pure. At Ludwigshafen, when the Seventh Tirailleurs left for Frankfurt, patrols had to be sent out to drive away the German women from the

barracks, where they were kissing the colored troops through the window gratings.

CONCLUSIONS.

I. The wholesale atrocities by French Negro colonial troops alleged in the German press, such as the alleged abductions, followed by rape, mutilation, murder, and concealment of the bodies of the victims are false and intended for political propaganda.

II. A number of cases of rape, attempted rape, sodomy, attempted sodomy, and obscene mishandling of women and girls have occurred on the part of French Negro colonial troops in the Rhinelands. These cases have been occasional and in restricted numbers, not general or widespread. The French military authorities have repressed them severely in most cases and have made a very serious effort to stamp the evil out. The amount of evidence necessary to convict in such cases is a very delicate matter to express opinion upon. However, the number of acquittals is not large and there is nothing surprising about these acquittals, except in one case where a girl of 14 years was known carnally. In this case the acquittal followed upon the claim that the girl had consented.

III. As a rule the number of convictions and the thoroughness of the reports of the investigations and trials indicate the very earnest effort of the French trial authorities to do justice and to stamp out the evil by stern repressive measures. That their sentences are often milder than ours would be is largely due to extenuating circumstances found in the evidence according to their rules of evidence which are very different from ours, and to the fact that in general French courts do not punish these crimes as severely as American and English courts do.

IV. The discipline of the Senegalese Tirailleurs was not always good as evidenced by the refusal of some of them to get aboard transports at Marseille when ordered to Syria.

HENRY T. ALLEN.

The SECRETARY OF STATE,
Washington, D. C.

APPENDIX VI.

COBLENZ, *August 19, 1920.*

SECRETARY OF STATE,
Washington, D. C.:

In a communication from the French high commissioner to the general commanding the French Army of occupation the former requests that instructions be given all members of that Army concerning their relations with and attitude toward German civilians. The French general has adopted the suggestion, and by means of conferences, orders, and schools in the units of his command, is instructing all officers and men that the occupying forces are not in Germany to provoke the Germans but as a guaranty that the terms of the treaty shall be carried out and that all members of the Army must be dignified, courteous, and just, thus setting the example to the German population of tolerance in order that good will and mutual respect may be established and promoted and ill will and hatred overcome. This is most encouraging and hopeful and should be productive of great good. This has been the governing principle of the American occupation, and since coming to the commission I have urged the application of this principle throughout the entire occupied region. Millerand has heartily approved the action of the French high commissioners and of the commanding general. Recently French relations have been more antagonistic than at any other period since the signing of the peace treaty.

ALLEN.

APPENDIX VII.

JUNE 19, 1920.

AMERICAN MISSION,
Berlin (Germany).

Your 625, June 15, 11 a. m.

Department is in receipt of frequent protests from various organizations and individuals against conduct of French troops in occupied region, particularly alleged mistreatment of German women by French black troops. The wording of these protests suggests that they are inspired by a propaganda agency and are based on reports in German press. Department assumes that you are not in a position to definitely determine the facts in the matter but requests your opinion. Please forward by mail press clippings and other information you may be able to obtain on the subject.

COLBY.

APPENDIX IX.

No. 464.

JULY 16, 1920.

The SECRETARY OF STATE,
Washington.

SIR: Adverting to my dispatch No. 442, of July 5, and to my telegrams Nos. 806 and 807, of July 12, and No. 812, of July 15, I have the honor to transmit herewith a translation of a newspaper account of the so-called American protest meeting against the use by France of colored troops in the occupied Rhineland area, held in Berlin on the evening of July 14. I beg likewise to inclose a copy of the issue of the European Press (formerly the Continental Times) dated July 9, which contains an article by Rutledge Rutherford announcing the meeting in question. This article states that the American speakers were to be Col. Edwin Emerson, Miss Ray Beveridge, Hermann George Scheffauer, Edith Talbot Scheffauer, Lora Vincent, John De Kay, Rutledge Rutherford, and Agatha M. Bullitt. The three last-named persons did not actually appear, however, although messages were read from Messrs. De Kay and Rutherford. Other than these Americans, the only speaker was a German woman from the Rhineland; but messages were read from E. D. Morel, Henri Barbusse, Jean Longuet, and others.

A member of the commission who attended the meeting informs me that the large auditorium of the university was crowded long before the meeting opened, and that the audience, composed largely of women, was most enthusiastic. The newspaper account does not, however, give an accurate impression of the tone adopted by the speakers, inasmuch as mention of the bitterly anti-French and anti-American character of the addresses is apparently omitted, whereas it was expression of these sentiments which created the greatest applause. In fact, the meeting took on more the character of a violent chauvinistic gathering than a protest against the black troops. Miss Beveridge and Mr. Scheffauer were particularly vehement in their attacks on President Wilson and the United States Government and devoted most of their time to assailing America for her entrance into the

war, while Col. Emerson directed his thrusts chiefly at France. It is interesting to note that Miss Beveridge, who has now spoken more than once on this subject, is invariably introduced as one who has done much for German children by aiding the work of the American Quakers in Germany. The head of the Quaker mission in Berlin informs me, however, that Miss Beveridge has not now and has never had any connection with their activities, in spite of her repeated efforts to become associated with them, and that her persistence and such misstatements as that referred to above have caused them great embarrassment.

During the course of the meeting, letters were read from Mrs. Bayard Taylor and Prof. Thomas C. Hall, but I am inclined to believe that the writers were not acquainted with the circumstances under which the meeting was held.

(Signed)

ELLIS LORING DRESEL,
American Commissioner.

JANUARY 31, 1921.

Hon. STEPHEN G. PORTER,
House of Representatives.

SIR: Referring to my letter of January 17, 1921, concerning the propaganda being carried on as to the conduct of the French black troops in the occupied territory of Germany, I have the honor to inclose for your information a paraphrase of a telegram received from the American ambassador in Paris giving the official statement as to the number and origin of the French troops of occupation at the present time.

I have the honor to be, sir,

Your obedient servant,

BAINBRIDGE COLBY.

[Telegram from American Ambassador at Paris, Jan. 29, 1921.]

The total number of troops in the French Army of occupation was 86,000 in December; 16,386 of this number were Moroccans and Algerians and 3,224 were Malgaches. The remainder were white. The figures for January are approximately the same.

Properly speaking, there are no black troops. The Moroccans and Algerians are Arabs of the Mussulman religion and are entirely distinct from the Negro race. The Malagaches are Malays from Madagascar.

Incidents occurring between these colored troops and the natives of the occupied district, and which have been investigated by French military authorities, have been in the proportion of 1 to 1,594 men. About one-fourth of such cases have resulted in condemnations of from 30 days to 10 years' imprisonment, according to the gravity of the charge. The remaining cases have been dismissed on account of inability to substantiate charges or because of a lack of good faith on the part of German authorities who brought charges.

The French Government has made no attempt to officially disprove the accusations concerning the behavior of the troops. It has, however, unofficially supplied facts and figures through its press agencies to various countries. So far as I am able to ascertain, the recent behavior of these troops has been on an average with the conditions above reported.

The delay on the part of the foreign office in supplying this information after several requests was not due to lack of interest, but to difficulty in obtaining figures. That office has promised further information within a few days, which I shall forward as soon as it is received.

WALLACE.

FEBRUARY 11, 1921.

Hon. STEPHEN G. PORTER,
House of Representatives.

SIR: Again reverting to my letter of January 17, 1921, in regard to the House joint resolution No. 433, concerning French colored troops in occupied Germany, I beg to refer to Appendix X of that letter, which was a photostat copy of a leaflet entitled "The Black Evil," and bearing the American flag at the top. This matter was brought to the attention of the American commissioner in Berlin, with instructions to make inquiries in regard to its origin.

I am now in receipt of a telegram from Mr. Dresel stating that the minister for foreign affairs, Mr. Simons, assures him "emphatically that the foreign office has had nothing to do with this propaganda, of which he utterly disapproves as injurious to Germany." Mr. Simons further stated that if he could discover who was financially responsible for this leaflet he would insist on these activities being stopped.

I beg to send this information to you as pertinent to the subject of joint resolution No. 433, which is being examined by your committee.

I have the honor to be, sir,

Your obedient servant,

NORMAN H. DAVIS.

TRANSCRIBER'S NOTES:

Obvious typographical errors have been corrected.

No Appendix VIII appears in the original.

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